Black Beauty

A simplified retelling

Original story by Anna Sewell

The same journey. Clearer, shorter English.

Abridged and retold for Speak Boldly Intermediate reading practice

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1. What my mother taught me

My first memories were of a pleasant field and my mother’s company. I was a young horse then, curious about the world beyond the gate. My mother taught me to do my work well and to remain gentle. She also knew that a horse’s happiness depended greatly on the people who controlled its life.

When I was old enough, I was trained to accept a saddle, a rider and a carriage. The process was strange, but the people treated me patiently. I learned what was expected without being frightened into obedience.

Eventually, I was sold to Squire Gordon at Birtwick Park. Mrs Gordon gave me the name Black Beauty. There I met Merrylegs, a small pony, and Ginger, a spirited chestnut mare.

Ginger did not trust people as easily as I did. She had been treated roughly. Listening to her, I began to understand that bad behaviour could be the result of suffering, not simply a bad nature.

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2. Good care is practical

At Birtwick, the coachman John Manly and the young groom James Howard understood horses. They noticed our food, our rest and the condition of our feet. Their kindness was more than affectionate words.

One night, a stable caught fire while we were away from home. Smoke and noise terrified the horses. James entered calmly and led us out. His familiar voice helped when unfamiliar orders would have frightened us further.

Later, a young replacement groom, Joe Green, was left to care for me after I had worked extremely hard on an urgent journey. He did not know that I needed warmth and proper attention. I became very ill.

Joe was distressed when he understood his mistake. He had not wanted to hurt me. But lack of knowledge could still cause harm. He listened and learned, and became more careful.

My good home ended when Mrs Gordon’s health required the family to leave England. Ginger and I were sold together.

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3. Fashion and cruelty

Our new owners valued a fashionable appearance. They used a bearing rein to force our heads into a high position. It made pulling difficult and prevented us from moving comfortably.

Ginger resisted fiercely. I endured it, but endurance did not make it harmless. People praised the way we looked without asking what that appearance cost us.

Then a groom named Reuben Smith took me out and drank heavily. He ignored a loose shoe and rode me dangerously fast. I fell on the rough road. Smith died, and my knees were badly injured.

Although I recovered enough to work, the scars meant I was no longer considered suitable for the same kind of household. I was sold again.

My strength, health and value seemed to change according to what people wanted from me. I could not explain that the injury had come from someone else’s decisions. I could only go where I was taken.

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4. London streets

After time in hired work, I came into the care of Jerry Barker, a London cab driver. Jerry, his wife Polly and their children treated me as part of their working life, not as a machine that could be used without limit.

The streets were noisy and exhausting. Some passengers kept us waiting in terrible weather. Others demanded dangerous speed. Jerry tried to protect both his horses and his principles, even when refusing a fare meant losing money.

I saw other horses struggling under loads they could hardly move. I met Ginger again. She was thin, tired and being worked beyond her strength. Her lively resistance had been worn away.

Later, I saw the body of a chestnut horse being carried away and believed it might be hers. I hoped her suffering had ended, though I grieved for the friend I had known at Birtwick.

Jerry’s fairness gave me a good life within hard work. But even a kind owner could not control every change ahead.

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5. Worn down

Jerry became seriously ill. His family had to leave the cab trade, and once again I was sold. I worked for a corn dealer whose driver, Jakes, often overloaded the cart.

One day, a woman noticed me struggling up a hill. She asked Jakes to loosen the bearing rein so I could lower my head and pull more effectively. Once he did, the task became easier. She had seen a simple change that could reduce suffering.

Later, I passed to Nicholas Skinner’s cab business. The horses were driven hard and rested too little. I became thinner and weaker. At last, under another exhausting demand, I collapsed.

I was no longer treated as worth protecting. At a sale, a farmer named Thoroughgood and his grandson Willie noticed that beneath my poor condition I was a well-made horse. They bought me and allowed me time, food and gentle care.

For once, being weak did not lead immediately to another demand. It led to rest.

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6. Recognised

As I recovered, the farmer looked for a suitable home for me. I was sold to a household of ladies who needed a steady horse and were willing to treat him well.

Their groom examined my markings and the scars on my knees. He recognised me. It was Joe Green, the boy from Birtwick who had once been so upset by his mistake.

He was an experienced man now. He remembered my earlier life and told the family who I was. They promised that I would not be sold again.

I had known people who were cruel, people who were careless and people who were kind. The differences had shaped my whole life, though I had never been able to choose my owners.

Now my work was manageable, my food was good and the hands around me were considerate. In my quiet home, I could rest without fearing the next sale. Sometimes I dreamed of the old days and the friends who had shared them.

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Words to keep

Groom — a person who cares for horses. John Manly was an experienced groom.

Bearing rein — a strap that keeps a horse’s head raised. The fashionable bearing rein caused pain.

Endure — to suffer through something difficult. Beauty endured work he could not refuse.

Overload — to put too much weight on something. The driver overloaded the cart.

Neglect — failure to provide necessary care. Neglect weakened the working horses.

Considerate — careful about another being’s needs. Beauty finally found considerate owners.

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A question to carry with you

What changes when a story is told by the being who must endure the work, rather than by the person giving the orders?

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